

Chapter 6 — Devotional Paths to the Divine

Bhakti and Sufi Traditions

The one-line point: For a thousand years, saints across India said the same thing in a dozen languages — **God is reachable directly, priests are unnecessary, and caste is irrelevant.** ★ **This is the single highest-yield chapter in Class 7, and one of the highest in the whole NCERT History series.**

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India
Sub-discipline	Religious & intellectual history — the Bhakti and Sufi movements
Period	~8th century – 17th century
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> AND <i>Art & Culture</i> — asked from both , relentlessly
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★★★★ <i>Indian culture</i> — <i>art forms, literature</i> : asked verbatim in 2014 . Also Indian Society (caste reform), Essay
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★★★★★, Indian Society (GS1) ★★★★★ (caste, gender, social reform), Ethics (GS4) ★★ (compassion, humility, service), Polity (GS2) ★ (composite culture, secularism's roots), Modern India (the 19th-c. reform movements build on this)
Weightage	★★★★★ — the top chapter of this book
Overlaps with	Class 6 Ch.6 (Buddha/Mahavira doing the same thing 1,800 years earlier), Class 12 Theme 6 (<i>Bhakti-Sufi Traditions</i> — the advanced version of this chapter)

 **This chapter appears again, in far more depth, as Class XII Theme 6.** Learn it properly here and Class XII becomes revision rather than new material.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** what social conditions produced the idea of bhakti.
- ☐ **Distinguish Nayanars from Alvars** — deity, numbers, texts, key names. ★★
- ☐ **Compare Shankara and Ramanuja** — Advaita vs Vishishtadvaita. ★★
- ☐ **Describe Virashaivism** — Basavanna, *vachanas*, and what it rejected. ★★
- ☐ **Name** the Maharashtra saint-poets and explain their **rejection of renunciation**. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the Nathpanthis, Siddhas and Yogis.
- ☐ **Explain Sufism** — *shariat, khanqah, dargah, pir, silsila, zikr, sama*. ★★★★★
- ☐ **Name** the **Chishti** chain of teachers and their locations. ★★

- ☐ **Distinguish** the two north Indian strands — those who **rejected** orthodoxy (Kabir, Nanak) from those who **worked within** it (Tulsidas, Surdas). ★★
- ☐ **Describe Kabir** — background, texts, language, and what he attacked. ★★
- ☐ **Describe Baba Guru Nanak** — *langar*, *dharmsal*, Gurmukhi, the succession, the **Guru Granth Sahib**. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why the Sikh movement became **political** when Kabir's did not. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why **vernacular composition** was the decisive strategic choice. ★★

Start Here: The Same Argument, 1,800 Years Apart

Cast your mind back to **Class 6, Chapter 6**. Around 600 BCE, the Buddha and Mahavira said: *ritual is expensive and useless, priests are unnecessary, birth does not determine worth* — **and they said it in Prakrit, the language people actually spoke**.

Now look at what happens from the eighth century CE onwards:

THE BHAKTI/SUFI ARGUMENT (8th – 17th century CE)

God is reachable DIRECTLY
No priest needed
No elaborate ritual needed
Caste is irrelevant to salvation
Composed in the VERNACULAR:
Tamil, Kannada, Marathi, Hindi,
Awadhi, Assamese, Punjabi, Persian

THE BUDDHIST/JAIN ARGUMENT (6th century BCE, Class 6 Ch.6)

Liberation is reachable directly
No priest needed
No elaborate ritual needed
Birth does not determine worth
Taught in PRAKRIT/PALI, not
Sanskrit

🔑 **The same structural move, made twice, 1,800 years apart.** Both times the trigger was similar: a **rigid, expensive, birth-based religious order**, and a **rising social group** (merchants then; craftspersons, peasants, traders and labourers now) with resources but no ritual status.

★ **If you can state that parallel in a Mains answer, you have said something genuinely analytical rather than merely descriptive.**

Why bhakti emerged — NCERT's own account

Before large kingdoms: different groups worshipped
THEIR OWN gods and goddesses

|
| people brought together through the growth
| of TOWNS, TRADE and EMPIRES

NEW IDEAS DEVELOP:

- all living things pass through countless cycles of BIRTH AND REBIRTH performing good deeds and bad
- all human beings are NOT EQUAL EVEN AT BIRTH
- social privileges came from birth in a "noble" family or a "high" caste <-- the subject of many learned texts

MANY PEOPLE WERE UNEASY WITH SUCH IDEAS

Turned to the BUDDHA or the JAINAS -- overcome social differences and break rebirth through PERSONAL EFFORT

Attracted to the idea of a SUPREME GOD who could deliver humans from bondage if approached with DEVOTION (bhakti) -- advocated in the BHAGAVADGITA

★ How local gods became Puranic gods — the absorption mechanism

Step
Shiva, Vishnu and Durga came to be worshipped as supreme deities through elaborate rituals
Gods and goddesses worshipped in different areas came to be IDENTIFIED with Shiva, Vishnu or Durga
Local myths and legends became a part of the Puranic stories
Methods of worship recommended in the Puranas were introduced into the local cults
★ Eventually the Puranas also laid down that it was possible for devotees to receive the grace of God REGARDLESS OF THEIR CASTE STATUS
The idea of bhakti became so popular that even Buddhists and Jainas adopted these beliefs

 **This is an assimilation protocol, and a very effective one.** A local deity is not suppressed — it is **re-labelled as a form of Shiva/Vishnu/Durga**, its myth is **merged into the Puranic corpus**, and Puranic ritual is **installed alongside** local practice. Nothing is destroyed; everything is absorbed and re-badged.

 **This is the single best answer to "how did Hinduism accommodate such diversity?"** — it did not enforce uniformity, it **absorbed**. Compare it with Ch.5, where **tribes** were absorbed into caste society by the same logic. **Same mechanism, applied to gods instead of people.**

PART A — THE BHAKTI TRADITION

1 ★ ★ ★ South India: Nayanars and Alvars

The earliest bhakti movement, 7th–9th centuries, in Tamil country.

	NAYANARS	ALVARs
Devoted to	★ SHIVA	★ VISHNU
Number	★ 63	★ 12
Best known	Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar, Manikkavasagar	Periyalvar, his daughter ANDAL , Tondaradippodi Alvar, Nammalvar
Compilations	★ <i>TEVARAM</i> and <i>TIRUVACAKAM</i>	★ <i>DIVYA PRABANDHAM</i>

 **Memory hook: "Naya-NAR → NAtaraja → SHIVA. ALvar → ALmost Vishnu."** Or simply: **63 Nayanars for Shiva, 12 Alvars for Vishnu.** The numbers are asked directly.

What made them radical ★★

Feature	Detail
Social origin	They came from ALL CASTES — including those considered "untouchable" like the PULAIYAR and the PANARS ★
The 63 Nayanars' backgrounds	Potters, "untouchable" workers, peasants, hunters, soldiers, Brahmanas and chiefs
Their stance	★ Sharply critical of the Buddhists and Jainas
Their message	Ardent love of Shiva or Vishnu as the path to salvation
Their sources	Drew on the ideals of love and heroism found in SANGAM literature and blended them with the values of bhakti ★
Their method	Went from place to place composing exquisite poems in praise of the deities enshrined in the villages they visited, and set them to MUSIC

🔗 **The Sangam link is a lovely cross-reference to Class 6 Ch.8.** Sangam poetry's *aham* (love) and *puram* (heroism) themes were **repurposed** — the language of romantic love and martial valour was turned toward a deity. **Existing literary conventions carrying a new devotional payload.**

⚠️ **Note the awkward fact NCERT does not hide:** these saints were **hostile to Buddhists and Jainas**. Bhakti was inclusive about **caste** but **competitive about sect**. A balanced answer says both.

🏛️ Bhakti meets the temple ★

Between the **tenth and twelfth centuries**, the **Chola and Pandya kings built elaborate temples around many of the shrines visited by the saint-poets, strengthening the links between the bhakti tradition and temple worship**. This was also when their **poems were compiled**, and when **hagiographies** — religious biographies — of the Alvars and Nayanars were composed.

🎯 **Note the irony, because it drives the next section.** A movement that began as **personal, direct devotion needing no institution** was **captured by royal temple-building** within three centuries. **That institutionalisation is exactly what Basavanna reacted against.**

★ **Hagiography** = a religious biography of a saint. NCERT flags that **we use these texts as sources** — so apply the usual caution: they are devotional, not neutral.

2 ★★ Philosophy: Shankara and Ramanuja

A guaranteed comparison question.

	SHANKARA	RAMANUJA
Born	★ KERALA, 8th century	★ TAMIL NADU, 11th century
Influenced by	—	★ The ALVARS
Doctrine	★ ADVAITA — the oneness of the individual soul and the Supreme God, which is the Ultimate Reality	★ VISHISHTADVAITA — qualified oneness: the soul, even when united with the Supreme God, remained DISTINCT
Nature of Brahman	Formless and without any attributes	Vishnu, with attributes and grace
The world	★ An illusion — MAYA	Real
Path to salvation	★ Renunciation of the world and the path of KNOWLEDGE (<i>jnana</i>)	★ Intense DEVOTION to Vishnu; Vishnu's grace helps the devotee attain the bliss of union
Legacy	The dominant philosophical system of Hinduism	★ Greatly inspired the new strand of bhakti that developed in NORTH INDIA subsequently

🔴 The one-line discriminator: Shankara — knowledge, illusion, renunciation, absolute oneness. Ramanuja — devotion, grace, the soul stays distinct.

📖 If it helps: Shankara says the individual soul and Brahman are **the same object with two references** — the appearance of separateness is a rendering artefact (*maya*). Ramanuja says they are **distinct objects in a permanent relationship** — union without loss of identity. **Identity vs. composition.**

3 ★ ★ Basavanna's Virashaivism

The reaction against temple-centred bhakti.

Aspect	Detail
Founder	★ BASAVANNA
Companions	★ Allama Prabhu and AKKAMAHADEVI
Where and when	★ KARNATAKA, mid-TWELFTH century
Their sayings	★ VACHANAS

What they argued for and against:

✓ For	✗ Against
Equality of ALL human beings	Brahmanical ideas about caste
	Brahmanical treatment of WOMEN ★
	★ ALL forms of RITUAL and IDOL WORSHIP

★ Basavanna's *vachana* — worth knowing, it's beautiful and quotable:

The rich,
Will make temples for Shiva.
What shall I,
A poor man,
Do?

MY LEGS ARE PILLARS,
THE BODY THE SHRINE,
THE HEAD A CUPOLA OF GOLD.

Listen, O Lord of the meeting rivers,
Things standing shall fall,
But the moving ever shall stay.

🌀 **Unpack the last two lines, because that is where the argument lives.** *"Things standing shall fall, but the moving ever shall stay."* The **stone temple** — the thing that stands — will fall. The **living body** — the thing that moves — endures. **He is not being poetic about poverty; he is claiming that the built temple is inferior to the living devotee.**

★ **This is one of the most powerful anti-ritual statements in Indian literature**, and it directly answers NCERT's question *"What is the temple that Basavanna is offering to God?"* — **his own body.**

Deploy it for: GS1 (social reform, critique of caste and gender), Essay (equality, the sacred and the institutional), and Art & Culture (the *vachana* as a literary form).

4 ★ ★ Bhakti in Maharashtra — The Humanist Turn

Thirteenth to seventeenth centuries. Saint-poets whose songs in **simple Marathi** continue to inspire people.

The saints

DNYANESHWAR (Gyaneshwar), NAMDEV, EKNATH, TUKARAM

★ Women like **SAKHUBAI**

★ The family of **CHOKHAMELA**, who belonged to the "untouchable" **MAHAR caste**

Their focus: the ★ **VITTHALA** temple (a form of Vishnu) at ★ **PANDHARPUR**, and the notion of a **personal god residing in the hearts of all people.**

★ ★ ★ What makes this tradition distinctive

THEY REJECTED:

- all forms of RITUALISM
- outward display of PIETY
- social differences based on BIRTH
- *** and even the idea of RENUNCIATION ***

THEY PREFERRED:

- to LIVE WITH THEIR FAMILIES
- EARNING THEIR LIVELIHOOD like any other person
- while HUMBLy SERVING FELLOW HUMAN BEINGS IN NEED

A NEW HUMANIST IDEA EMERGED:

*** BHAKTI LAY IN SHARING OTHERS' PAIN ***

As the Gujarati saint NARSI MEHTA said:

"THEY ARE VAISHNAVAS WHO UNDERSTAND THE PAIN OF OTHERS."

★★★ This is the most important idea in the chapter for GS4 Ethics and for Essay.

Every previous tradition in this chapter offered an **escape** — renounce the world (Shankara, the Nathpanthis), or lose yourself in devotion. The Maharashtra saints said the opposite: **stay in the world, do your job, raise your family, and measure your devotion by whether you can feel another person's pain.**

"**Bhakti lay in sharing others' pain**" and **Narsi Mehta's line** are directly quotable in answers on **compassion, empathy, service, and the ethics of public life**. Gandhi's favourite bhajan was Narsi Mehta's *Vaishnav Jan To* — which makes the link to modern India explicit.

★ **Tukaram's *abhang*** (a Marathi devotional hymn):

*"[He who identifies] with the battered and the beaten / Mark him as a saint / For God is with him... He treats a slave as his own son / Says Tuka, I won't be tired to repeat again / **Such a man is God in person.**"*

★ **And Chokhamela's son Karmamela — a rare voice of protest from inside the tradition:**

*"**You made us low caste, / Why don't you face that fact, Great Lord?** / Our whole life — left-over food to eat. / **You should be ashamed of this.** / You have eaten in our home. / How can you deny it? / Chokha's son Karmamela asks / **Why did you give me life?**"*

🔗 **Read that carefully — it is not a devotional poem, it is an accusation.** A Mahar poet is **holding God responsible for caste** and demanding an answer. NCERT includes it deliberately.

★ **This is exceptional material for GS1 on caste and for Essay.** It demonstrates that critique of the caste order came **from within the devotional tradition and from the oppressed themselves**, not only from later reformers. It also anticipates Ambedkar's argument by six centuries.

5 Nathpanthis, Siddhas and Yogis

Aspect	Detail
Who	The Nathpanthis, Siddhacharas and Yogis
What they criticised	The ritual and other aspects of conventional religion and the social order , using ★ simple, logical arguments
What they advocated	★ Renunciation of the world
Path to salvation	Meditation on the FORMLESS Ultimate Reality and the realisation of oneness with it
Methods	★ Yogasanas, breathing exercises and meditation — intense training of mind and body
Their following	★ Particularly popular among "low" castes
★ Their significance	" <i>Their criticism of conventional religion created the ground for devotional religion to become a popular force in northern India.</i> "

🔗 **That last line is why they matter and why they get asked.** They were not themselves a mass devotional movement — they were **the solvent** that dissolved the authority of conventional religion in the north, **preparing the ground for Kabir and Nanak**. Note also the resemblance to the Sufis (below): both trained the body and mind to perceive differently, and NCERT explicitly draws the comparison.

PART B — ISLAM AND SUFISM

6 The Sufis

The setting

Fact	Detail
Islam's core	Strict MONOTHEISM — submission to one God
8th–9th centuries	Religious scholars developed the Holy Law (SHARIAT) and the theology of Islam
The Sufis	Muslim MYSTICS . They rejected outward religiosity and emphasised  love and devotion to God and compassion towards all fellow human beings
Their tension with orthodoxy	 They often rejected the elaborate rituals and codes of behaviour demanded by Muslim religious scholars
Their goal	 "They sought union with God much as a LOVER SEEKS HIS BELOVED , with a disregard for the world."
Their output	Poems expressing their feelings , and a rich prose literature including anecdotes and fables
Great Sufis of Central Asia	 GHAZZALI, RUMI and SADI

 **The lover–beloved metaphor is the defining feature of Sufi expression** — and it is exactly the same device the Alvars, Nayanars and Mirabai used. **Two traditions, arriving independently at romantic love as the language of devotion.** Strong Mains point on the convergence of Bhakti and Sufi idioms.

The methods — learn these terms

Term	Meaning
 ZIKR	Chanting of a name or sacred formula
Contemplation	Meditative reflection
 SAMA	Singing
 RAQS	Dancing
Discussion of parables	Teaching through stories
Breath control	As with the Yogis
 PIR	The master under whose guidance training took place
  SILSILA	A  spiritual genealogy of Sufi teachers — each following a slightly different method (tariqa) of instruction and ritual practice
  KHANQAH	A hospice — where Sufi masters held their assemblies
  DARGAH	The tomb of a Sufi saint

 **Silsila** literally means "chain". It is an **unbroken chain of transmission from master to disciple**, authenticating a teacher by tracing the lineage back. **Authority is established by provenance rather than by institutional office** — a genuinely different model of legitimacy from an ordained clergy.

★ ★ The Chishti silsila — the chain to memorise

The CHISHTI silsila was among the most influential orders.
Its long line of teachers:

KHWAJA MUINUDDIN CHISHTI		AJMER
OUTBUDDIN BAKHTIAR KAKI		DELHI
BABA FARID		PUNJAB
KHWAJA NIZAMUDDIN AULIYA		DELHI
BANDANAWAZ GISUDARAZ		GULBARGA

🧠 The saint–place pairings are a stock matching question. Memory hook: "Ajmer, Delhi, Punjab, Delhi, Gulbarga" — the order moves south over time, ending in the Deccan.

A large number of Sufis from Central Asia settled in Hindustan from the ★ eleventh century onwards, a process strengthened with the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate (Ch.3), when several major Sufi centres developed all over the subcontinent.

🏠 The *khanqah* and the *dargah* ★ ★

At the <i>khanqah</i>	At the <i>dargah</i>
Sufi masters held assemblies	The tomb of a Sufi saint
Devotees of all descriptions — including members of the royalty and nobility, and ordinary people — attended	Became a place of PILGRIMAGE
They discussed spiritual matters, sought blessings in solving worldly problems, or simply attended the music and dance sessions	★ To which thousands of people of ALL FAITHS thronged
Sufis were regarded as masters with miraculous powers that could relieve others of their illnesses and troubles	

★ ★ "Thousands of people of all faiths" is the phrase that matters. The *dargah* is the clearest institutional expression of **composite culture** in medieval India — a shared sacred space that did not require anyone to change religion to enter it. Ajmer Sharif remains exactly that today.

🎯 Deploy this in GS1 (composite culture), GS2 (the social roots of Indian secularism), and Essay. Pair it with Akbar's *sulh-i kul* (Ch.4) and Ashoka's Rock Edict XII (Class 6 Ch.7) for a three-point argument that pluralism in India is an old practice, not a modern import.

🌿 The Rishi order of Kashmir ★

Fact	Detail
When	Flourished in the 15th and 16th centuries
Founder	★ SHEIKH NURUDDIN WALI, also known as ★ NUND RISHI
Impact	Had a deep impact on the life of the people in Kashmir ; shrines dedicated to Rishi saints are found in many parts of Kashmir

🎯 A distinctively Kashmiri, indigenous Sufi order — the name *Rishi* itself signals the blending with local tradition. Useful and specific for any answer on regional syncretism or on Kashmir's cultural history.

★ Rumi's verse — the argument in eight lines

Jalaluddin Rumi, a great thirteenth-century Sufi poet from IRAN who wrote in PERSIAN:

*"He was not on the Cross of the Christians. I went to the Hindu temples. In none of them was there any sign. He was not on [the Kaaba at] Mecca. He was not there. I asked about him from Avicenna [the philosopher]... **I looked into my heart. In that, his place, I saw him. He was in no other place.**"*

🎯 **Set this beside Kabir's poem below and the resemblance is startling** — both search the institutions of both religions, find nothing, and locate God in the heart. **NCERT explicitly invites the comparison** (its question asks how Kabir's ideas relate to Basavanna's and Rumi's). **Three saints, three religions, three languages, one conclusion.** That is a Mains paragraph on its own.

PART C — 🌿 NORTH INDIA AFTER THE 13th CENTURY

7 ★★ ★ The Two Strands

The context: an age when **Islam, Brahmanical Hinduism, Sufism, various strands of bhakti, and the Nathpanthi/Siddha/Yogi traditions influenced one another.** New kingdoms were emerging and people were taking up new professions. ★ **Ordinary people — especially CRAFTSPERSONS, PEASANTS, TRADERS and LABOURERS — thronged to listen to these new saints and spread their ideas.**

★★ **The crucial distinction — this is asked:**

STRAND 1: REJECTED ORTHODOXY	STRAND 2: WORKED WITHIN IT
KABIR BABA GURU NANAK	TULSIDAS SURDAS
"rejected ALL orthodox religions"	"accepted existing beliefs and practices but wanted to make these ACCESSIBLE TO ALL"

🎯 **Both strands democratised access; they differed on whether the existing tradition had to be destroyed or opened up.** Getting this distinction right is the difference between a vague answer and a precise one.

The saints of Strand 2 and the regional traditions

Saint	Deity	Work	Language
★ TULSIDAS	RAMA	★ RAMCHARITMANAS — important both as an expression of devotion and as a literary work	★ AWADHI (used in eastern Uttar Pradesh)
★ SURDAS	KRISHNA	★ Sursagara* , Surasaravali , *Sahitya Lahari	Braj
★ SHANKARADEVA (Assam)	VISHNU	★ Kirtana-ghosha ; began the practice of setting up ★ SATRA — houses of recitation and prayer , a practice that continues to date . His doctrine: Eka Sarana Nama Dharma	★ ASSAMESE
Dadu Dayal, Ravidas	—	—	Hindi
★ MIRABAI	KRISHNA	Innumerable bhajans	Rajasthani/Braj

👑 ★ ★ Mirabai

Fact	Detail
Who	A Rajput princess married into the royal family of MEWAR in the ★ SIXTEENTH century
★ Her guru	Became a disciple of RAVIDAS , a saint from a caste considered "untouchable"
Devoted to	KRISHNA
Her songs	★ Openly challenged the norms of the "upper" castes and became popular with the masses in RAJASTHAN and GUJARAT

★ Her song:

*"Ranaji, **I have left your norms of shame, and false decorum of the princely life.** I have left your town. And yet Rana why have you kept up enmity against me? **Rana you gave me a cup of poison. I drank it laughing. Rana I will not be destroyed by you.**"*

★ ★ **Mirabai is exceptional on three counts at once**, which is why she is asked so often:

1. **A woman** asserting spiritual autonomy against her marital family and the state
2. **A princess** who took an **"untouchable" saint as her guru** — inverting caste hierarchy in the most visible way possible
3. Her songs **survived orally among ordinary people**, not in court manuscripts

🔗 NCERT's question — **"why do you think ordinary people preserved the memory of Mirabai?"** — **has a real answer:** because she **defied the same hierarchies that constrained them**, and did it in a language and a song-form they could carry. **Prime GS1 material on gender and caste.**

★ ★ Why the vernacular mattered — the decisive point

"A unique feature of most of the saints is that their works were composed in REGIONAL LANGUAGES and COULD BE SUNG. They became immensely popular and were handed down ORALLY from generation to generation. Usually the POOREST, MOST DEPRIVED COMMUNITIES and WOMEN transmitted these songs, OFTEN ADDING THEIR OWN EXPERIENCES. Thus the songs as we have them today are as much a creation of the saints as OF GENERATIONS OF PEOPLE WHO SANG THEM."

★ ★ ★ **This paragraph is the intellectual high point of the chapter.** Three claims, each significant:

1. **Vernacular + singable = mass reach.** No literacy required, no priest required, no manuscript required
2. **The transmitters were the poorest communities and women** — precisely those excluded from Sanskrit learning
3. ★ **They added their own experiences** — so the corpus is **collectively authored**. The "text" is not a fixed thing a saint wrote; it is **what centuries of singers made of it**

📖 It is an **oral, distributed, append-only tradition with no central authority and no canonical version** — and its resilience comes precisely from having no single point of control. Contrast the *tawarikh* of Ch.3: written, elite, court-sponsored, and dependent on patronage to survive.

🔗 **For Mains this is your answer to "why did the Bhakti movement succeed where earlier reform did not?" — the delivery mechanism, not just the message.**

8 ★ ★ ★ A Closer Look: KABIR

Fact	Detail
Background	Brought up in a family of ★ Muslim JULAHAS (WEAVERS) settled in or near ★ BENARES (Varanasi)
Biography	★ "We have little reliable information about his life"
His verses	★ SAKHIS and PADS — said to be composed by him and sung by wandering <i>bhajan</i> singers
★ Preserved in	The ★ GURU GRANTH SAHIB, PANCH VANI and BIJAK
Language	★ A form of spoken HINDI widely understood by ordinary people; he also sometimes used cryptic language (<i>ulatbansi</i> , "upside-down sayings")
His theology	★ Believed in a FORMLESS Supreme God ; the only path to salvation was through <i>bhakti</i>
His followers	★ Drawn from BOTH Hindus and Muslims

★ ★ What he attacked — note the word NCERT uses:

*"Kabir's teachings were based on a **complete, indeed VEHEMENT, rejection of the major religious traditions. His teachings openly ridiculed all forms of external worship of BOTH Brahmanical Hinduism AND Islam, the pre-eminence of the priestly classes, and the caste system.**"*

★ His poem — know it, it's the most quoted text in the chapter:

O Allah-Ram present in all living beings
Have mercy on your servants, O Lord!

WHY BUMP YOUR HEAD ON THE GROUND, <- ridicules Muslim prayer
WHY BATHE YOUR BODY IN WATER? <- ridicules Hindu ritual bath

You kill and you call yourself "humble"
But your vices you conceal.

Twenty-four times the Brahmana keeps the ekadasi fast
While the Qazi observes the Ramzan
Tell me why does he set aside the eleven months
To seek spiritual fruit in the twelfth?

Hari dwells in the East, they say
And Allah resides in the West,
*** SEARCH FOR HIM IN YOUR HEART, IN THE HEART OF YOUR HEART;
THERE HE DWELLS, RAHIM-RAM. ***

★ ★ ★ Notice the perfect symmetry of the attack — he criticises Hindu and Muslim ritual in the same breath, with the same force, and fuses the divine names (**Allah-Ram, Rahim-Ram**). He is not syncretising politely; he is saying **both sets of externals are equally beside the point.**

🌀 Compare with Rumi (above): both search the institutions of both faiths, find nothing, and end **in the heart**. NCERT sets them side by side on purpose.

Deploy Kabir for: GS1 (social reform, composite culture), Essay (the critique of ritual, universalism), Art & Culture (nirguna bhakti, vernacular poetry).

9 ★ ★ ★ A Closer Look: BABA GURU NANAK

NCERT notes: "We know more about Baba Guru Nanak (1469–1539) than about Kabir."

Life and institutions

Fact	Detail
Dates	★ 1469 – 1539
Born at	★ TALWANDI (Nankana Sahib, in Pakistan)
Centre established at	★ KARTARPUR (Dera Baba Nanak, on the river RAVI) — after travelling widely
Worship	Regular worship consisting of the singing of HIS OWN HYMNS
★★ LANGAR	Irrespective of their former CREED, CASTE or GENDER, his followers ATE TOGETHER in the common kitchen
★ DHARMSAL	The sacred space thus created — ★ now known as GURDWARA

★★ The *langar* is the institutional masterstroke, and it deserves emphasis in any answer.

Caste is enforced above all through **rules about who may eat with whom**. By making **shared eating the entry condition** to the community, Nanak did not merely *preach* equality — he **built a daily practice that made caste observance impossible** for anyone who participated. **An idea embedded in an institution outlives an idea merely preached.**

 It converts a belief into a **protocol that must be executed to participate** — compliance is structural, not voluntary.

★★ The succession and the scripture

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BABA GURU NANAK (d. 1539)
| appointed a follower, LEHNA, as successor -->
| known as GURU ANGAD, "signifying that he was a
| PART OF Baba Guru Nanak himself"
v
GURU ANGAD
| compiled Nanak's compositions, added his own,
| in a NEW SCRIPT: *** GURMUKHI ***
v
The THREE SUCCESSORS of Guru Angad also wrote
*** UNDER THE NAME "NANAK" ***
|
v
GURU ARJAN, 1604 -- compiled ALL of these
| ...and ADDED the writings of
| KABIR, BHAGAT NAMDEV and GURU TEGH BAHADUR
v
1706 -- authenticated by GURU GOBIND SINGH
v
*** GURU GRANTH SAHIB *** -- the holy scripture of the Sikhs
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★ Two details that get asked and are easy to miss:

- **Guru Angad's successors wrote under the name "Nanak"** — the authorial identity was the office, not the individual
- **The Guru Granth Sahib includes Kabir and Namdev** — saints from outside the Sikh line. **A scripture that canonises other traditions' saints** is a remarkable fact and excellent evidence of composite religious culture

★ ★ Why the movement became political

Stage	Detail
The following	Grew through the 16th century; belonged to a number of castes but ★ traders, agriculturists, artisans and craftsmen predominated
Why those groups?	★ Nanak insisted his followers must be HOUSEHOLDERS and adopt productive and useful occupations , and contribute to the general funds of the community
The town	By the early 17th century, ★ RAMDASPUR (AMRITSAR) developed around the central Gurdwara, ★ HARMANDAR SAHIB (Golden Temple)
★ ★ Its status	It was virtually SELF-GOVERNING — modern historians call the early-17th-century Sikh community ★ "a state within the state"
The clash	★ Emperor JAHANGIR saw them as a potential threat and ordered the ★ EXECUTION OF GURU ARJAN in 1606
Politicisation	The movement got politicised in the seventeenth century , culminating in the institution of the ★ KHALSA by GURU GOBIND SINGH in 1699
The outcome	The community of the Sikhs, called the ★ KHALSA PANTH , became a POLITICAL ENTITY

★ ★ Nanak's teaching — the three principles

His own terms	Remembered today as	Meaning
NAM	NAM-JAPNA	Right worship / right belief
DAN	VAND-CHHAKNA	Welfare of others / helping others (sharing)
ISNAN	KIRT-KARNA	Purity of conduct / honest living

And the core positions:

- ★ Emphasised the **worship of ONE GOD**
- ★ Insisted that **CASTE, CREED or GENDER was IRRELEVANT for attaining liberation**
- ★ ★ **"His idea of liberation was NOT that of a state of inert bliss but rather THE PURSUIT OF ACTIVE LIFE WITH A STRONG SENSE OF SOCIAL COMMITMENT."**

★ ★ ★ That last sentence explains everything that follows, and NCERT says so explicitly:

*"Baba Guru Nanak's idea of equality had **social and political implications**. This might partly explain **the difference between the history of the followers of Baba Guru Nanak and the history of the followers of [saints] like Kabir, Ravidas and Dadu, whose ideas were VERY SIMILAR** to those of Baba Guru Nanak."*

🎯 This is the analytical question of the chapter, and it makes an outstanding Mains answer:

Kabir and Nanak taught almost the same thing. Why did one produce a community, a scripture, a town, an army and eventually a state — and the other produce only verses?

The answer, from the text itself:

Kabir	Nanak
Liberation through personal devotion	Liberation as active life with social commitment
No institution	Langar, dharmsal, a named successor
No fixed community	Followers must be householders in productive occupations
No common fund	Contributions to community funds
No territorial centre	Kartarpur, then Ramdasapur/Amritsar
Verses collected by others	Scripture compiled by his own successors

Ideas alone do not reproduce. Institutions do. Compare Class 6 Ch.6 on why **Buddhism declined in India** — it was monastery-centred, so destroying the monasteries destroyed it; Hinduism was distributed across households and survived. **Same lesson, opposite direction.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Nayanars / Alvars ★★ ★	63 Nayanars → SHIVA (<i>Tevaram, Tiruvacakam</i> ; Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar, Manikkavasagar) · 12 Alvars → VISHNU (<i>Divya Prabandham</i> ; Periyalvar, Andal , Tondaradippodi, Nammalvar)
Their social origin ★	All castes , including "untouchable" Pulaiyar and Panars ; critical of Buddhists and Jainas
Sangam link	Blended Sangam ideals of love and heroism with bhakti
Shankara ★ ★	Kerala, 8th c. ; Advaita ; Brahman formless, without attributes ; world = <i>maya</i> ; knowledge + renunciation
Ramanuja ★ ★	Tamil Nadu, 11th c. ; influenced by Alvars ; Vishishtadvaita ; soul remains distinct ; devotion to Vishnu
Virashaivism ★ ★	Basavanna, Allama Prabhu, Akkamahadevi ; Karnataka, mid-12th c. ; <i>vachanas</i> ; against caste, against the treatment of women, against ritual AND idol worship
Maharashtra saints ★ ★	Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Eknath, Tukaram, Sakhubai, Chokhamela (Mahar caste); Vitthala temple at Pandharpur ; rejected renunciation
Narsi Mehta ★	Gujarati saint — " <i>They are Vaishnavas who understand the pain of others</i> "
Nathpanthis/Siddhas/Yogis ★	Formless Ultimate Reality; yogasanas , breath control; popular among " low " castes; prepared the ground for northern bhakti
Sufi terms ★ ★ ★	<i>shariat*</i> , <i>zikr</i> , <i>sama</i> , <i>raqs</i> , <i>pir</i> , <i>silsila</i> , <i>tariqa</i> , <i>khanqah</i> , <i>*dargah</i>
Chishti chain ★ ★	Muinuddin Chishti–Ajmer, Qutbuddin Bakhtiar Kaki–Delhi, Baba Farid–Punjab, Nizamuddin Auliya–Delhi, Bandanawaz Gisudaraz–Gulbarga
Central Asian Sufis	Ghazzali, Rumi, Sadi ; Sufis settled in India from the 11th century
Rishi order ★	Kashmir, 15th–16th c. , Sheikh Nuruddin Wali / Nund Rishi
Rumi	13th c. , from Iran , wrote in Persian
Strand 1 vs 2 ★ ★	Kabir & Nanak rejected orthodoxy; Tulsidas & Surdas made it accessible
Tulsidas ★ ★	Rama ; <i>Ramcharitmanas</i> ; AWADHI
Surdas ★	Krishna ; <i>Sursagara, Surasaravali, Sahitya Lahari</i>
Shankaradeva ★ ★	Assam ; Vishnu ; <i>satra</i> ; <i>Kirtana-ghosha</i> ; Assamese ; <i>Eka Sarana Nama Dharma</i>
Mirabai ★ ★	Rajput princess of Mewar, 16th c. ; disciple of RAVIDAS ; Krishna ; popular in Rajasthan and Gujarat
Kabir ★ ★ ★	Muslim <i>julaha</i> (weaver) family near Benares ; <i>sakhis*</i> and <i>*pads</i> ; in Guru Granth Sahib , Panch Vani, Bijak ; formless God ; followers both Hindu and Muslim
Guru Nanak ★ ★ ★	1469–1539 ; Talwandi ; Kartarpur ; <i>langar</i> ; <i>dharmsal</i> → Gurdwara
Guru Angad ★ ★	Successor (Lehna); compiled Nanak's works; created GURMUKHI
Guru Arjan ★ ★	Compiled in 1604 , adding Kabir, Namdev, Tegh Bahadur ; executed by JAHANGIR in 1606
Guru Gobind Singh ★ ★	Authenticated the scripture in 1706 ; founded the ★ KHALSA in 1699
Ramdasapur/Amritsar ★	Harmandir Sahib ; " a state within the state "
Nanak's three principles ★	<i>nam-japna*</i> , <i>kirt-karna</i> , <i>*vand-chhakna</i>

Traps:

- "**Nayanars worshipped Vishnu**" → **FALSE**. **Shiva**. Alvars = Vishnu

- "There were 12 Nayanars and 63 Alvars" → **REVERSED**. 63 Nayanars, 12 Alvars
- "The Alvars and Nayanars were tolerant of all sects" → **FALSE**. They were **sharply critical of Buddhists and Jainas**
- "Ramanuja taught that the soul merges completely and loses its identity" → **FALSE**. That's Shankara's Advaita; Ramanuja's soul **remains distinct**
- "Virashaivas accepted idol worship" → **FALSE**. They opposed **all ritual AND idol worship**
- "The Maharashtra saints advocated renunciation" → **FALSE**. They **rejected** it and lived as householders
- "Mirabai's guru was a Brahmana" → **FALSE**. Ravidas, from a caste considered "untouchable"
- "Kabir criticised only Hindu ritual" → **FALSE**. He ridiculed **both** Hindu and Muslim external worship
- "The Guru Granth Sahib contains only the Sikh Gurus' writings" → **FALSE**. It includes **Kabir and Bhagat Namdev**
- "Guru Arjan was executed by Aurangzeb" → **FALSE**. By **JAHANGIR, in 1606**
- "The Khalsa was founded in 1606" → **FALSE**. **1699**, by Guru Gobind Singh

Mains — this is a top-tier chapter

- ★★ ★ "Sufis and medieval mystic saints failed to modify either the religious ideas and practices or the outward structure of Hindu/Muslim societies to any appreciable extent. Comment." (**UPSC 2014**) — argue **both ways**: they transformed **religious idiom, language and access**, but **caste and ritual hierarchy substantially survived**. Use Chokhamela's son as evidence that the critique existed *and* that the condition persisted
 - ★★ ★ "Why did Guru Nanak's movement produce an enduring community while Kabir's, with near-identical ideas, did not?" — **institutions vs ideas**; use the table above
 - ★★ **Composite culture / GS2**: the **dargah** as shared sacred space + **Guru Granth Sahib canonising Kabir** + Akbar's **sulh-i kul** (Ch.4) + Ashoka's **RE XII** (Class 6 Ch.7)
 - ★★ **Indian Society**: Bhakti's challenge to caste — **and its limits**
 - ★★ **Gender**: Andal, Akkamahadevi, Sakhubai, Mirabai — women's voices across four regions and five centuries
 - ★★ **Ethics (GS4)**: "*bhakti lay in sharing others' pain*"; Narsi Mehta; Tukaram; Basavanna's body-as-temple
 - ★ **Language/Art & Culture**: vernacular composition as the mechanism of mass reach; the **collectively authored** oral corpus
-

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Bhakti	Devotion to a chosen deity, open to all regardless of caste or gender
Nayanars / Alvars	Tamil saints devoted to Shiva / Vishnu
Tevaram, Tiruvacakam	Compilations of Nayanar songs
Divya Prabandham	Compilation of Alvar songs
Hagiography	A religious biography of a saint
Advaita	Shankara's doctrine of the oneness of soul and Brahman
Maya	Illusion — Shankara's view of the world
Vishishtadvaita	Ramanuja's "qualified oneness" — the soul remains distinct
Virashaivism	Basavanna's movement in Karnataka
Vachana	A Virashaiva saying
Abhang	A Marathi devotional hymn
Shariat	The Holy Law of Islam
Zikr	Chanting of a name or sacred formula
Sama / Raqs	Singing / dancing (Sufi practice)
Pir	A Sufi master
Silsila	A spiritual genealogy of Sufi teachers
Tariqa	A Sufi order's method of instruction
Khanqah	A Sufi hospice where assemblies were held
Dargah	The tomb of a Sufi saint; a place of pilgrimage
Julaha	Weaver — Kabir's community
Sakhis / Pads	Kabir's verse forms
Langar	The common kitchen where all eat together
Dharmsal	Nanak's sacred space; now Gurdwara
Gurmukhi	The script created by Guru Angad
Khalsa / Khalsa Panth	The community instituted by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699
Satra	Shankaradeva's house of recitation and prayer in Assam

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **Bhakti** arose as unease with the idea that people are **unequal at birth**; the *Bhagavadgita* advocated a **Supreme God reachable through devotion**.
2. **Local deities were absorbed** into Shiva/Vishnu/Durga, local myths into the **Puranas** — and the Puranas conceded that **grace was available regardless of caste**.
3. **63 Nayanars (Shiva)** — *Tevaram, Tiruvacakam*. **12 Alvars (Vishnu)** — *Divya Prabandham*. From **all castes**, including "untouchable" **Pulaiyar and Panars**; **critical of Buddhists and Jainas**; blended **Sangam** love and heroism with devotion.
4. **Chola and Pandya kings built temples** around their shrines — **institutionalising** the movement.

5. **Shankara** (Kerala, 8th c.): **Advaita**, formless Brahman, world as **maya**, **knowledge and renunciation**. **Ramanuja** (Tamil Nadu, 11th c.): **Vishishtadvaita**, **devotion to Vishnu**, the **soul stays distinct**.
6. **Basavanna's Virashaivas** (Karnataka, mid-12th c.) wrote **vachanas**, demanded **equality**, and rejected **caste, the treatment of women, ritual and idol worship**. "*My legs are pillars, the body the shrine.*"
7. **Maharashtra (13th–17th c.):** Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Eknath, **Tukaram, Sakhubai, Chokhamela** (Mahar). Focused on **Vitthala at Pandharpur**. ★ **Rejected renunciation** — stay a householder and **share others' pain**.
8. **Nathpanthis, Siddhas, Yogis** attacked conventional religion with **logical arguments** and **prepared the ground** for northern bhakti.
9. **Sufis** were Muslim mystics who rejected outward religiosity, sought **union with God as a lover seeks the beloved**, and trained through **zikr*, sama, *raqs** under a **pir**, forming **silsilas**. **Ghazzali, Rumi, Sadi**.
10. **Chishti chain:** Muinuddin (**Ajmer**) → Bakhtiar Kaki (**Delhi**) → Baba Farid (**Punjab**) → Nizamuddin Auliya (**Delhi**) → Gisdaraz (**Gulbarga**). **Khanqah** = hospice, **dargah** = tomb, thronged by **people of all faiths**.
11. **Kashmir's Rishi order** — Sheikh Nuruddin Wali (**Nund Rishi**), 15th–16th c.
12. **North India split two ways: Kabir and Nanak rejected** orthodoxy; **Tulsidas** (*Ramcharitmanas*, **Awadhi**) and **Surdas** (Krishna) made it **accessible**. **Shankaradeva** in Assam founded the **satra**.
13. **Mirabai** — Mewar princess, disciple of the "untouchable" **Ravidas**, devotee of Krishna, whose songs **defied upper-caste norms**.
14. ★ **The saints composed in regional languages, in singable form**, transmitted **orally by the poorest communities and women, who added their own experiences** — a **collectively authored** tradition.
15. **Kabir** — Muslim **weaver** family near **Benares**; **sakhis*/pads** preserved in the **Guru Granth Sahib, Panch Vani, Bijak**; **vehemently rejected both** Hindu and Muslim externals; **formless God**; followers from both faiths.
16. **Nanak (1469–1539)** — Kartarpur, **langar** across creed, caste and gender, **dharmsal**. **Guru Angad** created **Gurmukhi**; **Guru Arjan compiled the scripture in 1604** (adding **Kabir and Namdev**) and was **executed by Jahangir in 1606**; **Guru Gobind Singh** founded the **Khalsa in 1699** and authenticated the **Guru Granth Sahib in 1706**.
17. ★ **Nanak's liberation was "active life with a strong sense of social commitment"** — householders in productive occupations, contributing to common funds. **That institutional design is why his movement became a community and a polity while Kabir's remained verses**.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements:
 1. There were 63 Nayanars devoted to Shiva.
 2. The songs of the Alvars were compiled in the *Divya Prabandham*.
 3. Both groups drew exclusively on Sanskrit literary conventions. → *1 and 2 only. They drew on **Sangam (Tamil)** ideals of love and heroism.*
2. With reference to Ramanuja, which is/are correct?
 1. He was born in Tamil Nadu in the eleventh century.
 2. He was influenced by the Alvars.
 3. He held that the soul merges into Brahman and loses all distinction. → *1 and 2 only. The soul **remains distinct** (Vishishtadvaita); statement 3 describes **Advaita**.*

3. The Virashaiva movement —

1. was initiated by Basavanna in Karnataka.
2. opposed caste and the Brahmanical treatment of women.
3. accepted idol worship while rejecting caste. → 1 and 2 only. It opposed **all ritual and idol worship**.

4. Consider the following pairs:

1. Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti — Ajmer
2. Baba Farid — Punjab
3. Bandanawaz Gisudaraz — Delhi → 1 and 2 only. Gisudaraz is associated with **Gulbarga**.

5. Which of the following are included in the *Guru Granth Sahib*?

1. Compositions of Guru Nanak
2. Verses of Kabir
3. Verses of Bhagat Namdev → All three.

6. Guru Arjan was executed in 1606 on the orders of — → *Emperor Jahangir*.

7. Mirabai became a disciple of — → *Ravidas, a saint from a caste considered "untouchable"*.

Mains style

8. "*Sufis and medieval mystic saints failed to modify either the religious ideas and practices or the outward structure of Hindu/Muslim societies to any appreciable extent.*" Comment. **(150 words) — UPSC 2014**
9. Kabir and Guru Nanak preached almost identical ideas, yet only one gave rise to an enduring community. Account for the difference. **(250 words)**
10. "*The Bhakti movement's success owed as much to its medium as to its message.*" Discuss. **(250 words)**
11. Examine the contribution of women saints to the Bhakti tradition. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Nayanars vs Alvars: deity, number, texts, two names each.
- State the difference between Advaita and Vishishtadvaita in one sentence.
- What did the Virashaivas reject, and what is Basavanna's "temple"?
- Why is the Maharashtra tradition called humanist?
- Define *silsila*, *khanqah*, *dargah*, *zikr*, *sama*.
- Name the Chishti chain with places.
- Who rejected orthodoxy and who worked within it, in north India?
- Give four institutional features Nanak created that Kabir did not.